

[Return to Search](#)**Original Page:** 180**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1958-1966**Coverage Date:** 1958-1966**Place Coverage:** G/Wi, Ghanzi District, Botswana**Section Title(S):** Interband Relationships

Visits are eagerly looked forward to and are greatly enjoyed. The abundance of company and its variety enhance the pleasure of a season of plentiful food. Nevertheless, social and subsistence resources cannot sustain such a super-band for very long without showing signs of strain. The presence of a large number of somewhat unfamiliar people brings problems of adaptation, and toward the end of a long visit, the numbers in mixed cliques decline and interaction tends to polarize according to band membership. Visits normally end well before a stage is reached at which mutual dissatisfaction or conflict would become apparent, and the alliance is not threatened by friction. There was, however, one instructive exception. In a year of exceptionally plentiful tsamas, one visiting band stayed for 3 months. Having numerical superiority and also a generally "pushing" manner, they dominated the home band after a few weeks. The remarks of joking partners across band boundaries became more and more pointed, cooperative ventures virtually ceased, and games, dances, and discussion increasingly became one-band occasions. There was even some talk among home-band members of moving away from the tsamas in order to shake off the visitors or to leave them in solitary possession. This, however, was too drastic a remedy in a year of such remarkable plenty, and the home band decided to stay among the melons and put up with the growing unpleasantness. The visit did not end until the winter frosts blighted the melons, by which time the alliance was also pretty well blighted, and in the subsequent years of my stay, contact between the two bands was diminished and diverted to other allies.

517

[Leisure Time Activities](#)

574

[Visiting And Hospitality](#)

578

[Ingroup Antagonisms](#)

628

[Inter-Community Relations](#)

This visit and its unhappy consequences illustrate the fragility of cooperation as well as the freedom that exists for alternation between sets of relationships that is given by voluntary, open associations such as band alliances. In the normal course of events alliances are not subjected to such strains. Interaction is only initiated in response to the need for company, for

574

[Visiting And Hospitality](#)

578

[Ingroup Antagonisms](#)

exchange of commodities, news, marriage partners, or for the need for refuge in times of local drought. If an ally is unable to provide for these needs, contact is not made. If a drought encompasses the territory of several bands, one band will not strain its relationship with other bands by invading a territory already short of food, which would be a fruitless waste of time and effort. Nor will there be any need for allies to threaten the alliance by refusing help, for help will not be asked when it is known that it cannot be given.

628
Inter-Community
Relations

As relationship networks, the four organized groupings of G/wi society may be compared: ■ 181

573
Cliques

1. *The household.* This is the most markedly unitary and distinctive; relationships are complementary and cooperative and only based on reciprocity to a small extent; statuses are distinctive and ranked in the parameters parent-child, sex, and relative age of sibling. The relationships undergo regular changes in the course of the developmental cycle. Propensity for alternation and substitution is minimal. Relationships are stable in their identity and personnel but not in geographical location. The relationship network is firmly bounded internally (i.e., is relatively impermeable and nonvoluntary), but there is a high individual valency for external, nonexclusive relationships. The unit has considerable capacity for independent action.

592
Household

2. *The clique.* Relationships are based on reciprocity and mutual selection; cognition of the identity of the network is weakly developed and the network is usually unstable over time. Its unitary nature is only discernible in contrast with other cliques in relation to band consensus and the unit has little, if any, capacity for independent action. The network is bounded geographically but not socially, and its existence is derived from the geographical factor. For its duration, the unit has higher internal than external valency of relationships. (Note: These are characteristics of cliques in whole-band camps, not of cliques in isolation, when they approximate to small bands in their characteristics.)

602
Kin Relationships
621
Community Structure

3. *The band.* The network is egalitarian in nature and based on reciprocity, common interest, cooperation, and, with respect to adults, voluntary recruitment. There is a great capacity for independent action by the unit for which consensus is a prerequisite. The stability of the identity of the network is little affected by changes of personnel or by the seasonal dispersal of personnel. The network is structurally open but is of finite size and is bounded by geographical barriers to external valency. Internal valency is high.

628
Inter-Community
Relations

4. *Band alliances.* The network is based on reciprocity and has a dimly perceived identity, its operations mostly taking place within the kinship framework. The network is structurally open and is readily amended or extended. It is activated sporadically in response to specific needs and generates few secondary needs. There is a limited capacity for unit action.

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